



Blazing cathedral

2019

A massive fire, most likely caused by an electrical fault, engulfed the centuries-old Notre Dame Cathedral in Paris, France. The fire melted the building's lead roof, and toppled its 96 m (315 ft) high spire.

Born this day

1452 Leonardo da Vinci, Italian artist and engineer. He is best known for his painting the *Mona Lisa* and for designing various flying machines.

1469 Guru Nanak, religious leader. A Hindu by birth, he travelled widely in search of spiritual truth and founded the Sikh religion.

Also on this day

1868 Members of the Indigenous Māori tribe were elected to New Zealand's parliament for the first time following the Māori Representation Act.

1945 The Bergen-Belsen concentration camp in Germany was liberated by British forces, exposing the horrific extent of Nazi war crimes.

1955 US entrepreneur Ray Kroc opened his first McDonald's franchise in Illinois, USA, later turning the fast-food company into a global success.

April

15

1941



Vought-Sikorsky VS-300

Russian-American aircraft designer Igor Sikorsky's helicopter set a record in the USA by staying in the air for 1 hour, 5 minutes, and 14.5 seconds. Sikorsky's design became the model for future helicopters.

Atlantic tragedy

1912

On its first voyage, the HMS *Titanic* – the largest and most luxurious steamship of its time – hit an iceberg and sank in the freezing North Atlantic Ocean. More than 1,500 passengers and crew died.

